The Noble Sūtra Called the Excellent Night

Āryabhadrarātrīnāmasūtra · Toh 974 · Derge Kangyur
འཕགས་པ་མཚན་མ་བཟང་པ་ཞེས་བྱ་བའི་མདོ།

The Noble Sūtra Called the Excellent Night, known in Sanskrit as the Āryabhadrarātrīnāmasūtra and in Tibetan as 'Phags pa mtshan mo bzang po zhes bya ba'i mdo, is a short discourse of the Buddha set at Rājagṛha, where the Blessed One is staying in the Bamboo Grove at the Kalandaka Feeding Ground. It opens with a radiant god who visits a monk at night on the bank of the Tapodā waters and asks whether he knows the Sūtra of the Excellent Night. When neither of them can recite it, the stage is set for the teaching itself, which in this tradition concerns how one should relate to past, future, and present in order to live a single night well. The work is Toh 974 in the Kangyur, where it is preserved among the collection of dhāraṇīs and related protective texts, and it is closely related to the version of the same sūtra found among the general sūtras.

In the language of India: ārya bhadrarātrī nāma svātra

In the language of Tibet: The Noble Sūtra Called the Excellent Night.

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was dwelling at Rājagṛha, in the Bamboo Grove at the Kalandaka Feeding Ground. At that time a certain monk was staying on the bank of the Tapodā waters of Rājagṛha.

Then, when night had fallen, a god of surpassing radiance went to where that monk was. He lit up the whole bank of the Tapodā waters, and he said this to the monk: "Monk, do you know the Sūtra of the Excellent Night?"

The monk replied, "Deva, I do not know the Sūtra of the Excellent Night. Deva, do you know the Sūtra of the Excellent Night or not?"

The god said, "Monk, I do not know the Sūtra of the Excellent Night either."

"Deva, then who is there who knows the Sūtra of the Excellent Night?"

The god said, "The Blessed One is dwelling here at Rājagṛha, in the Bamboo Grove at the Kalandaka Feeding Ground. Go to the Blessed One and ask him. Then hold it just as the Blessed One explains it to you, and strive at it." Having said this, the god vanished on the spot.

Then that monk rose at dawn and went to where the Blessed One was. He bowed his head at the Blessed One's feet and sat down to one side. Seated to one side, the monk said this to the Blessed One:

"Venerable One, last night, when it was dark, a god of surpassing radiance came to where I was. He filled the whole bank of the Tapodā waters with a vast light, and he said this to me: 'Monk, do you know the Sūtra of the Excellent Night?' I said this to him: 'Deva, I do not know the Sūtra of the Excellent Night. Deva, do you know the Sūtra of the Excellent Night or not?' He said this to me: 'Monk, I do not know the Sūtra of the Excellent Night either.' 'Deva, then who is there who knows the Sūtra of the Excellent Night?' He said this: 'Here at Rājagṛha, in the Bamboo Grove at the Kalandaka Feeding Ground, go to the Blessed One and ask him. Then hold this just as the Blessed One explains it to you, and strive at it.' Having said this, the god vanished on the spot. Venerable Blessed One, that is why I am asking you about this."

The Blessed One said, "Monk, do you know who that god was?"

The monk replied, "Venerable One, I do not know who that god was."

The Blessed One said, "That son of the gods is a leader of the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three, and he is called Candana."

The monk said, "Venerable One, I too wish to hear the Sūtra of the Excellent Night."

The Blessed One said, "Then, monk, listen well and closely, and keep it in mind, and I shall explain it to you. Monk, if a monk possesses three qualities, he is said to abide in the Sūtra of the Excellent Night. What are the three? They are these: he does not chase after the past, he has no hope for the future, and his nature is to abide without being carried away by present phenomena. If he possesses these three qualities, a monk is said to abide in the Sūtra of the Excellent Night."

When the Blessed One had said this, when the Sugata had spoken thus, the Teacher further said this:

"Do not chase after the past;
Have no hope for the future.
Whatever is past has ceased,
And the future has not yet come.
Whatever present phenomena there are,
Looking closely at each of them,

Not carried away by conceptual thought,
The wise come to understand them.
Who knows whether one will die as soon as tomorrow?
So make that effort this very day.
The Lord of Death and his great host
Are not known to us as kin.
May all sentient beings, all living creatures,
All bhūta spirits, and every one besides
Attain nothing but happiness,
And may all be free of afflictions.
May all see only what is good,
And may none of them fall into wrongdoing.
One who abides like this and strives hard
Has no slackness, by day or by night;
Therefore the Sage has always called this
The Sūtra of the Excellent Night."

Then, for the protection of all sentient beings, the Blessed One, having taught this Sūtra of the Excellent Night, spoke these garuḍa mantra formulas:

tadyathā bini biraṇi pani pūrani buddhamarte manini ṇiṇiṇiṇi ṭiṭiṭiṭi paraṭi gauri gandhari caṇḍali mataṃgi pukkasi bhamani dramidri dramidri śabari saralambhe hīnamadhamadhatrarani maholana dalabani dalabani dalabatte mahādalini calini muṣṭecakrapāti mahācakrabāti śabariśabari mahāśabari bhūcidgini bhūciraṅgini nimi nimoṅgiri niminadhiri bhūdhani svāhā

tadyathā eṭuṭuṭuṭu naṭumirṇi kirṇi edku siddatari calalu naṃtu naralamlu galalu ābatranono śekunirabaraṅsale tarake tare tarodtu nortu tilalalu bhūtabatiya batayiye svāhā

tadyathā aragarḍe naragarḍe baṃsuka pāyiye kapotakapayiyeyetabodhane svāhā

"Monk, whatever son of good family or daughter of good family, for the protection of all sentient beings, bears, holds, reads, brings to mind, or fully masters the Sūtra of the Excellent Night, its words, its verses, and the garuḍa mantra formulas, or teaches them extensively and correctly to others as well, fire will not harm that person's body, nor will poison, weapons, or water, nor punishment by kings, nor harm from thieves. That person will not die an untimely death, and will certainly attain nirvāṇa."

Wherever one may be born,
if one reads the Sūtra of the Excellent Night,
one will surely remember past lives, become an arhat,
and become a powerful lord as well.

By even a single reading, in every place,
from untimely death and death cut off midway,
so that one does not bring these upon oneself,
from untimely death and from what is contrary to the Dharma,
it guards all sentient beings and drives these away.

When illness, sorrow, and fear arise,
and in the distress of bewildering dreams,
if it is recited, it turns them into glory.

If someone writes it down and ties it
to the body of a man or a woman,
good fortune and splendor,
and that person's glory too, will arise.

However slight the nonvirtue
one has done by body, speech, or mind,
from all of these the Excellent Sūtra
protects against untimely death.

From kings, from water, fire, and lightning,
from bandits, illness, and enemies,
in battle and in strife as well,
recalling the Excellent One protects.

If one always recites this excellent spell
and these secret mantras,
people will not lose heart in any place.
Therefore recite this in your mind.

Homage to the tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas of the past, of the future, and of the present. Having paid homage, one should recite these vidyā-mantras: "By this vidyā-mantra may I prosper!

tadyathā nimi nimindhire timi timiṅgili trailokini alokini triśūladharaṇi akupiṇikrimikriti koli koli kudto kudto kutokisi kuti kupiti

Protect me and all sentient beings, together with Vajrapāṇi, from all fears, from all illnesses, from all poisons, from all fevers, from all grahas, from all

seizure by malevolent beings, from all bandits and thieves, from all humans and nonhumans, from fears, from harms, from all contagious diseases, from fighting, turmoil, wrongdoing, disputes, quarrels, and all fault-finding, from all misconduct of body, speech, and mind, and from every fear everywhere. Protect us! Protect us!

tadyathā hili mili cili ili mili biśīcana parṇaśabari cili cili svāhā"

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, those monks, that assembly endowed with every kind of being, and the world with its gods, humans, asuras, garuḍas, gandharvas, kinnaras, mahoragas, yakṣas, rākṣasas, pretas, and piśācas rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had said.

This completes The Noble Sūtra Called the Excellent Night.

It was translated and edited by the Indian preceptors Jinamitra and Dānaśīla and the chief editor and translator, the monk Yeshé Dé. It was then revised according to the new terminology and finalized.

Translator's Notes

• The water named □□□□□□□□□□□ (also □□□□□□□□□□□□) is taken as the Tapodā hot springs near Rājagṛha. This is the setting of the parallel Pāli discourse with the god Candana.

In the monk's retelling the text reads □□□□□. This is evidently a slip for □□□□□ "know", and is translated so.

The term □□□□□□□□□, literally "moving and soaring", is a Tibetan epithet of the garuḍa. The phrase □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is rendered "mantra formulas".

In the verse line □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, □□□□□□□ is read as "slackness, indolence".

The phrase □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is rendered literally as "not known to us as kin". The Pāli parallel says there is no bargaining with Death and his great host.

The text reads □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, which might also be construed as "through discernment". It is rendered "by conceptual thought", reading it as □□□□.

The opening phrase of the final paragraph, □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, is taken as the Buddha addressing the monk. It could also be read as a list: "a monk, a son of good family, or ...".
• The second verse is grammatically terse and difficult. The phrase rendered "death cut off midway" may instead refer to the intermediate state. The line rendered "so that one does not bring these upon oneself" could also be read as "without harming oneself." The phrase "bewildering dreams" may also mean "bad dreams." The phrase "together with Vajrapāṇi" is ambiguous in the Tibetan: it may name Vajrapāṇi as a fellow protector, or as one of those included among the protected.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.